

Software Requirements Specification for a Collaboration Platform for Project Studies

Report for Project Study

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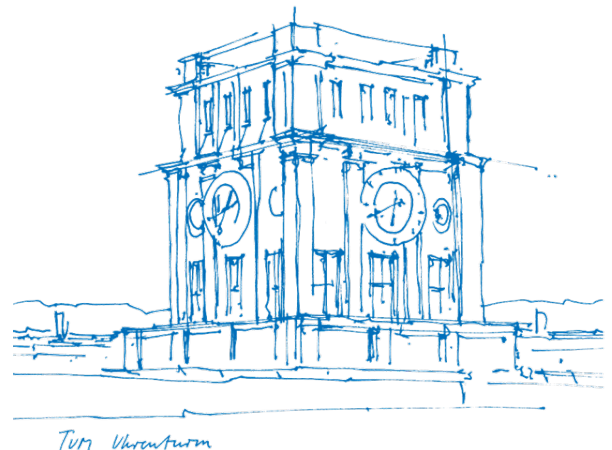
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Contents

1. Introduction	4
1.1. Purpose of this Document	4
1.2. Project Background and Motivation	4
1.3. Scope of the Platform	4
1.4. Definitions, Acronyms, and Abbreviations	4
1.5. Document Overview	4
2. Literature review	5
2.1. Requirements Engineering Grounding	5
2.2. Academia-Industry Collaboration	7
3. Research Approach and Limitations	9
3.1. Interview Methodology (stakeholder groups, question design)	9
3.2. Sample Overview and Limitations (explicit note on data thinness, especially company-side)	9
3.3. From Interview Insights to Requirements (how findings were translated, requirements framed as informed proposals, not validated findings)	9
4. Overall Description	10
4.1. Product Perspective	10
4.2. Stakeholder Groups and Their Roles (students, professors/supervisors, companies)	10
4.3. Assumptions and Constraints	10
4.4. Scope Boundary: TUM-Specific Focus (explicit justification: administrative/ collaboration processes differ significantly across universities, so single- institution depth was prioritized over shallow generality)	10
4.5. Transferability to Other Institutions (brief discussion of what would need to adapt for other universities)	10
4.6. Out-of-Scope Items (e.g. backend functionality not prototyped)	10
5. Stakeholder Needs (Pain Points)	11
5.1. Overview by Stakeholder Group	11
5.2. Student Pain Points	11
5.3. Professor/University Pain Points	11
5.4. Company Pain Points	11
5.5. Cross-Cutting Findings (pain points recurring across all three groups)	11
6. Functional Requirements	12
6.1. Prioritization Scheme (MoSCoW, criteria defined here. Requirements grounded in cross-cutting pain points and structurally independent of TUM-specific administration are prioritized higher)	12
6.2. [Functional Area 1]	12
6.3. [Functional Area 2]	12
6.4. [Functional Area 3]	12
6.5. [Functional Area 4]	12
7. Non-Functional Requirements	13

7.1. Usability	13
7.2. Security and Data Privacy	13
7.3. Maintainability / Extensibility	13
8. System Models	14
8.1. Use Case Diagram(s)	14
8.2. Key User Flows	14
9. Traceability and Prototype Alignment	15
9.1. Traceability Table: Interview Insight → Pain Point → Requirement ID	15
9.2. Prototype Coverage Table: Screen → Requirement ID	15
9.3. Requirements Without Prototype Coverage (brief justification)	15
10. Assumptions, Risks, and Open Issues	16
11. Appendices	16
12. Declaration of authorship	16
References	17

1. Introduction

1.1. Purpose of this Document

1.2. Project Background and Motivation

1.3. Scope of the Platform

1.4. Definitions, Acronyms, and Abbreviations

1.5. Document Overview

2. Literature review

In this section we provide a review of industry and academic practices in requirements engineering, focusing on the elicitation of requirements from stakeholders. We describe the sources for our methodology, including the choice of standard, the interview-based elicitation method, and the literature on small-sample saturation. We also discuss traceability practices and prioritization schemes relevant to this project.

2.1. Requirements Engineering Grounding

2.1.1. Selection and Adaptation of the Requirements Engineering Standard

This specification follows ISO/IEC/IEEE 29148:2018 (Society, 2018) – the current international standard for requirements engineering, which supersedes IEEE 830-1998 (Society, 1998). The predecessor addressed the specification document alone, whereas 29148 covers the requirements process as a whole, including elicitation, analysis and validation. Consequently, such a form is more appropriate for this project, since much of what follows concerns how requirements were derived from stakeholder interviews and how strongly each is supported. The standard is applied in scaled-down form appropriate to a single-semester project and extended with a literature review section to meet the academic requirements of a project study report.

2.1.2. Interview-Based Requirements Elicitation

Semi-structured interviews were used to explore stakeholder needs without assuming pre-defined system requirements. Ferrari et al. (2022) show that interviews support an iterative elicitation process in which stakeholder initial ideas are progressively clarified and refined into requirements through the dialogue and iterative feedback. Accordingly, this project first analyzed interview data inductively to identify recurring needs and pain points, which then served as the basis for deriving platform requirements.

2.1.3. Sample Adequacy and Thematic Saturation

MacQueen et al. (1998) defined thematic saturation as the point at which no new codes emerge from additional interviews. And, the number of interviews required to reach the point of saturation is a recurring question in qualitative research.

Guest et al. (2006) found that little new information emerged after the first 12 of their 60 interviews.

Hennink et al. (2017) argue that the answer depends on what saturation is taken to mean. No new codes appeared in their data after 9 interviews, but arriving at a rich understanding of those codes took between 16 and 24. These figures come from fairly uniform groups of participants.

Hagaman & Wutich (2017) worked across 4 sites and found that 16 interviews or fewer sufficed within a single group, while themes running across groups needed 20 to 40.

These thresholds provide a basis for assessing the 26 interviews conducted for this study rather than merely reporting their number. The student group, at 13 interviews, exceeds the code-saturation threshold reported by Hennink et al. and falls within the range Hagaman and Wutich associate with thematic convergence in a single group; the pain points reported for students in Section 5.2 can therefore be regarded as reasonably stable. The company, professor and university-staff groups, at 5, 5 and 3 interviews respectively, fall below every threshold cited above, and findings specific to them are correspondingly treated as indicative. The cross-cutting findings in Section 5.5, which draw on the full sample of 26, sit within the range associated with cross-group themes, though not at its upper end. Requirements are accordingly framed throughout as informed proposals rather than validated findings.

2.1.4. Requirements Traceability

Requirements traceability is the ability to follow a requirement forward into design and implementation and backward to the source it came from. Gotel & Finkelstein (1994), drawing on interviews and questionnaires with over 100 practitioners, distinguish these two directions and argue that the backward one is where projects usually fail.

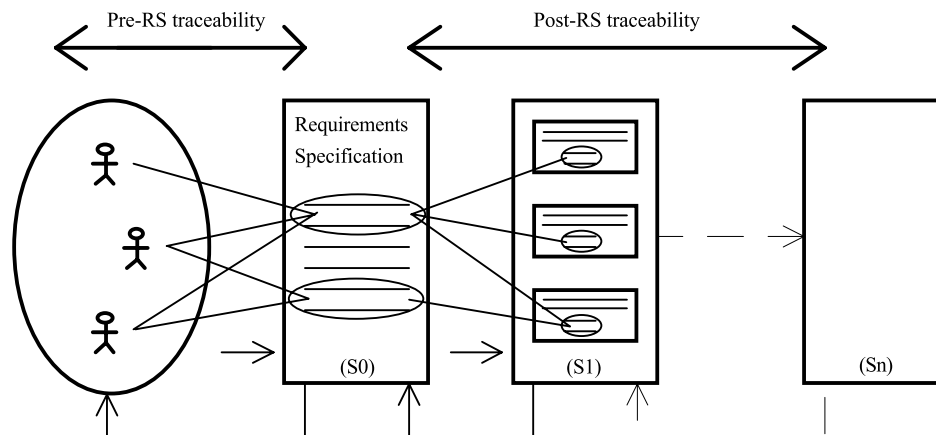


Figure 1: Illustration of the two directions of requirements traceability from Gotel & Finkelstein (1994)

Post-specification traceability, linking requirements to what was built from them, is comparatively well supported by tools. Pre-specification traceability, linking a requirement back to the stakeholder statement and rationale that produced it, tends to be neglected, and most of the problems attributed to poor traceability turn out to originate there.

Section 9 is organised along both directions: Section 9.1 provides the pre-specification record, tracing each requirement back to its pain point and interview material, while

Section 9.2 and 9.3 provide the post-specification record, mapping requirements forward to prototype screens and accounting for those left unimplemented.

2.1.5. Requirements Prioritization

Prioritization techniques differ mainly in how much they demand of the team using them. Reviewing the field, Achimugu et al. (2014) find that pairwise methods such as the Analytic Hierarchy Process become impractical as requirement counts grow, and that cost-value approaches depend on effort and benefit estimates unavailable at this stage of a project. MoSCoW asks for neither, sorting requirements into four ordinal classes on judgement alone, which suits a small team working to a fixed deadline on requirements that have not been validated. The criteria used for that sorting are set out in Section 6.1.

2.2. Academia-Industry Collaboration

2.2.1. Collaboration friction as an established phenomenon

Collaboration between universities and companies has been studied extensively, and the difficulties it produces are documented rather than incidental. Ankrah & AL-Tabbaa (2015) synthesise a fragmented body of work into a process framework covering why the two sides collaborate, the forms collaboration takes, and the organisational obstacles that recur across national contexts. Coordination and communication problems appear throughout that literature, independent of country, discipline and collaboration format. Since this problem is documented across many institutions, the difficulties reported in Section 5 are treated as a specific case of it rather than as a local peculiarity.

2.2.2. Barriers and information asymmetry between stakeholder groups

Bruneel et al. (2010) separate two kinds of barrier to university-industry collaboration. Orientation-related barriers arise from differences in what each side is trying to achieve and on what timescale. Transaction-related barriers arise from the mechanics of working together, including administration and intellectual property. Prior collaboration experience reduces the first kind, while trust between the parties reduces both. Difficulties such as identifying the right contact person or establishing what expertise is available fall into the second category, which is where a platform can plausibly intervene. This distinction is used in Section 5.5 to organise the pain points that recur across stakeholder groups.

2.2.3. Divergent motivations of academic and industry partners

The two sides enter collaboration for different reasons. Perkmann et al. (2013) show that academic engagement is driven largely by research-related motives, including access to data, funding and problems worth studying, while firms pursue capability, talent and commercial application. Neither set of motives is illegitimate, but they are not automatically aligned, and the semester rhythm that governs university work rarely matches company

project timelines. A platform mediating between the two therefore cannot assume a shared objective; it has to make each side's constraints legible to the other. Section 5.5 returns to this point where the mismatch surfaced in the interview data.

2.2.4. Platforms and intermediaries as a category of solution

Where two parties struggle to find and evaluate each other, a third party can lower the cost of doing so. Howells (2006) develops a typology of innovation intermediaries and defines them as bodies acting as brokers between parties in the innovation process, performing functions such as scanning, matchmaking and coordination. The platform specified in this document sits in that category, with the difference that it serves three groups rather than two.

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9.2. Prototype Coverage Table: Screen → Requirement ID

9.3. Requirements Without Prototype Coverage (brief justification)

10. Assumptions, Risks, and Open Issues

11. Appendices

12. Declaration of authorship

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